CHAPTER 15

THE GATES OF THE WONDER WORLD OPEN

The great floodgates of the wonder-world swung open.

—HERMAN MELVILLE, *MOBY DICK*, CHAPTER 1 (1851)

Sometime coming up, perhaps just around the corner, there will be a nation—more likely, a consortium of nations—that will work the next major step in the human venture into space. Perhaps it will be brought about by circumventing bureaucracies and making efficient use of present technologies. Perhaps it will require new technologies, transcending the great blunderbuss chemical rockets. The crews of these ships will set foot on new worlds. The first baby will be born somewhere up there. Early steps toward living off the land will be made. We will be on our way. And the future will remember.

TANTALIZING AND MAJESTIC, Mars is the world next door, the nearest planet on which an astronaut or cosmonaut could safely land. Although it is sometimes as warm as a New England October, Mars is a chilly place, so cold that some of its thin carbon dioxide atmosphere freezes out as dry ice at the winter pole.

It is the nearest planet whose surface we can see with a small telescope. In all the Solar System, it is the planet most like Earth.